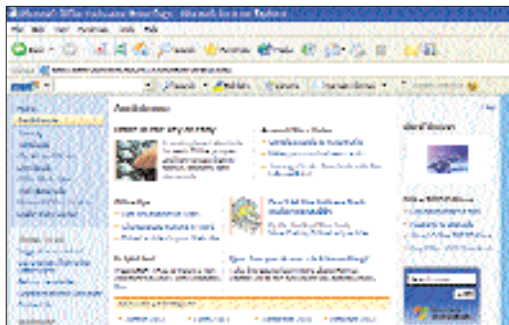


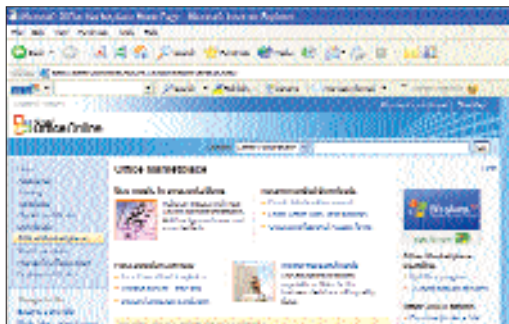
features or tools not already included in the MS Office suite. These are generally available as shareware or freeware downloads.

## Microsoft Downloads

Whether you want to update or patch your Microsoft operating system and office suite, or if you are a developer looking to get some Microsoft tools, you will find them all at Microsoft's dedicated Downloads site. Everything made by Microsoft, from DirectX to Windows Media Player is available for download at <http://www.microsoft.com/downloads/>



Help for Microsoft Office users



Get some cool third-party tools for Microsoft Office

You can choose from various categories including games, Office and home applications, updates, drivers, and so on. We searched for, and found, downloads for the latest version of DirectX, SQL Server 2005 books, the Service Packs for Windows 2000, and much more.

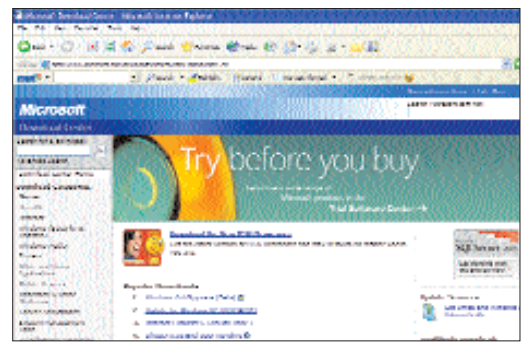
So far we have only looked at user resources, but there are also Microsoft resources for coders. Programmers that use Microsoft's Development Tools can also benefit from Microsoft's online resources.

## Microsoft Developer Network

The Microsoft Development Network (MSDN) is a programmers Mecca, and every coder needs to pay <http://msdn.microsoft.com> a visit if he or she plans on a career as one.

This site is not for the average user, and, perhaps, should contain a sign that says, "Warning: geeky language ahead". The page layout is cluttered, as usual, as programmers have no time or need for beautiful and well designed Web pages.

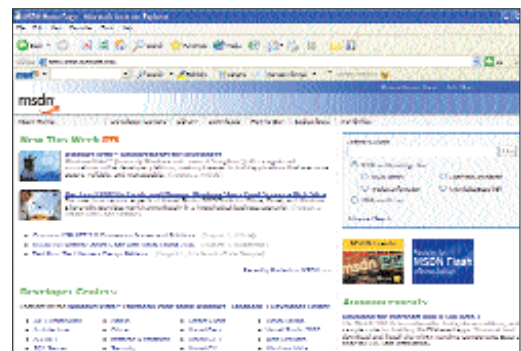
For the uninitiated, MSDN is the developer network that programmers that use Microsoft Development tools refer to for their programming needs. MSDN is available as a subscription, wherein you get exclusive information that adds



The Microsoft Download Center

value to the products that you are already using for development. As an MSDN member, you are also privy to previews, betas and first-looks at the latest versions of software.

MSDN now ships on DVDs, and contains content that is exclusive to it's members. Though the MSDN Web site is exhaustive, there is a lot of useful information available only on the DVD.



MSDN: A programmer's heaven

In no way do we imply that the Web site contains less critical information. For instance, if you are new to programming, you can head to the "Library" section to find content that will help you get started with programming, using illustrated examples.

You can visit the "Developer Community" to get more information from other developers working with the same tools as you. You can also watch Web casts and check for jobs at Microsoft in the "Training, Career and Events" section. In addition to all of this, there is a Download section that offers developer tools and resources such as code samples, SDK downloads and tools that integrate into other Microsoft products.

There is a special section dedicated to MSDN subscribers where they can download the latest tools that are not available publicly—for instance, the Windows Vista (formerly Longhorn) Beta 1 is only available as a download to MSDN subscribers. Developers and programmers should head off there and get a copy right now!

Whether you are a first time PC user or a seasoned programmer, there is a Microsoft Web site that can help you do more with your PC. If any of the sites mentioned in this article have helped you in any way, do write in and share your experience with us. ☐

[bhaskar\\_banik@thinkdigit.com](mailto:bhaskar_banik@thinkdigit.com)